

Project Name: UMass Marketplace

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Project Description:

UMass Marketplace is a buying and selling webpage for students who can create listings to sell items by uploading photos and adding key details (price, condition, category, short description, pickup location). Buyers can browse/search listings, and filter by category (textbooks, furniture, appliances, bikes, etc.) or price. Once someone is interested, buyers and sellers can message each other through an in-site text feature to ask questions or coordinate for pickup.

TASK 3 + 4:

Ethical concern: Selling illegal or prohibited items on UMass Marketplace

According to the ACM Code of Ethics, software developers must consider the potential harms their product may cause. One ethical concern to our project is the potential sale of illegal or prohibited items because our UMass marketplace allows students to post listings and connect with others to buy/sell items. It could be used to sell illegal or prohibited items (e.g., drugs, fake IDs, weapons, stolen goods). If we don't plan for this, the platform could enable harm to users and the campus community.

Principles we are incorporating (ACM "Analysis"):

- 1.2 Avoid harm: Prevent foreseeable harms by designing features that reduce dangerous misuse and by acting when harm is discovered.
- 1.1 Contribute to society and human well-being: The platform should support a safe community marketplace, not facilitate illegal activity.
- 2.3 Know and respect existing rules pertaining to professional work: We must consider legal obligations and university rules and ensure the product doesn't encourage violations.
- 1.3 Be honest and trustworthy: Be transparent with users about what is not allowed and what enforcement actions can occur.

We should proceed only if we include clear prevention and enforcement: publish a Prohibited Items policy, require users to agree to it at posting time, add report/block/report listing tools, implement automatic flagging (keywords/categories + suspicious patterns) with human moderation, and apply consistent actions (takedown, warnings, bans). This aligns the marketplace with community well-being while reducing the risk that our system enables illegal or harmful transactions. Ignoring these principles could result in harm and legal consequences for clients such as users and the university.

Under Principle 2, developers must act in the best interests of their client (students) and employer.

Principles we are incorporating with Principle 2 (ACM "Analysis"):

- **2.01** Competence & honesty: Be realistic about moderation/flagging limits and clearly communicate what the system can and cannot detect.
- **2.03** Authorized use of client/employer property: Use UMass systems/data only with proper approval (e.g., storage, authentication, logging, admin access) and document permissions.
- **2.05** Confidentiality: Protect user data (messages, listings, reports) and restrict access to moderators/admins; only share information when legally required or for safety.
- **2.06** Report likely project problems: If we can't moderate effectively with available time/resources, we should document the risk and notify the supervising staff/instructor/"client" early.
- **2.07** Report significant social issues: Treat illegal/prohibited-item activity as a serious social concern; document trends and report them to responsible authorities at UMass when needed.
- **2.09** Higher ethical concern overrides adverse interests: If pressure exists to "ship fast" without safeguards, we should raise the safety concern and escalate appropriately.

We should proceed only if the marketplace is built and run in UMass's best interests by 1) being honest about moderation limits, 2) following authorized use and confidentiality requirements for UMass/user data, and 3) promptly documenting and reporting risks (like illegal-item activity) to appropriate UMass authorities backed by clear policies and consistent enforcement.